

Milky Way visible from 13% of Malta?

A University of Malta study of night-sky brightness, and how it was reported

THE CLAIM

“...with the Milky Way being visible for only 12.8% of the area.”

Caruana et al., *Journal of Environmental Management*, 2020

Reported as “Milky Way only visible from 13% of Malta”.

Sky Quality Meter readings in 347 one-kilometre cells, 2017–2019.

VERDICT

SUPPORTED

Accurately reports a peer-reviewed measurement.

SUPPORTED

LARGELY
SUPPORTED

NOT
SUBSTANTIATED

MISLEADING

CONTRADICTED

MAIN RESULTS

12.8%

Milky Way visible

Bortle class 4 or darker; 13.5% on the world atlas threshold. No darker sky anywhere.

87%

Light-polluted area

Bortle class 5 or brighter across the islands; 96% on the island of Malta.

11%

World atlas, 2016

An independent satellite-based atlas gave a similar figure for Malta.

1.6%

Island of Malta, 2018/19

The class 4 area fell from 3.9% a year earlier. No newer survey found.

6–26%

Depends on the threshold

The study's own sensitivity test; 13% uses a standard threshold.

FAIR TO SAY

The headline matches the study. It describes 2017–2019; a repeat survey would show whether skies have darkened or brightened since.

WHAT WOULD SETTLE IT

☐ UM / ERA: a repeat survey since 2019.

☐ ERA / PA: national lighting guidelines.

☐ Readers: data from 2017–2019.

☐ See CC-106 on light and seabirds.